One more light, one more step

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

מעלין בקדש ואין מורידין

We rise in holiness and do not descend.

Shabbat 21b | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Beit Shammai and Beit Hillel discuss different ways to count the lights. Beit Hillel begins with one and adds each night; this is our practice. One explanation in the Gemara connects this to rising in holiness. Family connection: progress can happen in small steps. Yesterday's learning matters, and tonight we have another chance to grow. Missing a session does not stop you from joining again.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Tonight is Saturday night. Wait until Shabbat has ended before lighting or using a device. Customs differ about the order of Havdalah and Chanukah lighting at home; follow your family's practice. Tonight has two mitzvah lights, plus a separate shamash.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Take turns proposing one small, realistic addition to your learning or kindness this week. Choose one together. Say when you will do it and who will help.

Younger learners: How many mitzvah lights will we light tomorrow?
Older learners: Why might increasing the lights express something different from lighting eight every night?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Do we add or remove a light each night? 2. Does the shamash count as one of tonight's two mitzvah lights?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

In Shabbat 21b, compare counting the days still to come with counting the days already reached. Give the strongest explanation you can for each position before explaining our practice.

Sources: Shabbat 21b; Saturday night: Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 681:2.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Shabbat 21b | Two ways to count

Excerpt with an omission marked

והמהדרין מן המהדרין ב"ש אומרים יום ראשון מדליק שמנה מכאן ואילך פוחת והולך וב"ה אומרים יום ראשון מדליק אחת מכאן ואילך מוסיף והולך ... חד אמר טעמא דב"ש כנגד ימים הנכנסין וטעמא דב"ה כנגד ימים היוצאין וחד אמר טעמא דב"ש כנגד פרי החג וטעמא דבית הלל דמעלין בקדש ואין מורידין

For those who beautify the mitzvah most: Beit Shammai say to light eight on the first day and then decrease; Beit Hillel say to light one on the first day and then increase ... One explanation is that Beit Shammai count the days still to come, and Beit Hillel count the days already reached. Another connects Beit Shammai to the decreasing number of bulls offered on Sukkot, and Beit Hillel to the principle that we rise in holiness and do not descend.

2. Shulchan Aruch & Rema, O.C. 681:2 | One practice

Selected passage

מדליקין נר חנוכה בבהכ"נ קודם ההבדלה. הגה: וכ"ש בביתו שמדליק ואח"כ מבדיל שהרי כבר הבדיל בבהכ"נ.

In the synagogue, the Chanukah lamp is lit before Havdalah. Rema: All the more so at home, one lights and then recites Havdalah, since one has already recited Havdalah in the synagogue.

3. Taz on O.C. 681:2 | Another practice, concluding words

Selected passage

ראוי לו להבדיל בביתו ברישא והדר להדליק נ"ח

It is appropriate for him to recite Havdalah at home first, and afterward light the Chanukah lamp.

4. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1 | A separate light

Excerpt with an omission marked

ונוהגים להדליק נר נוסף כדי שאם ישתמש לאורה יהיה לאור הנוסף ... ויניחנו מרחוק קצת משאר נרות מצוה

The custom is to light an additional lamp so that, if one uses the light, it will be the light of the additional lamp ... One places it a little apart from the other mitzvah lights.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

These passages record differing practices. Follow your family's custom at home. All lighting is after Shabbat ends. In the Gemara, identify one reason based on counting and one based on holiness.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.